The story goes that the Brahman, excited by what he had been told, took his daughter to Pataliputra and offered her in marriage to the emperor Bindusara. Here again, the political circumstances of the third century BCE are accurately invoked in that the Brahman is shown as taking his daughter to the pre-eminent city of India, the political capital from where the Maurya king ruled. Unlike in earlier ages of multiple kingdoms and republics competing with each other, in the era in which Ashoka was born, as we have noted, large parts of the subcontinent had been brought within the political ambit of a sprawling empire whose monarch resided in Pataliputra. Certainly, for anyone with ambitions of greatness, it was logical, as in the case of the Champa Brahman, to be heading to that royal capital.

Meanwhile, the emperor was not ‘waiting’ for this girl from Champa to arrive in his court. By this time Bindusara had a substantial harem and is also said to have had an heir apparent, a son by the name of Susima. So, the Brahman’s beautiful daughter was not Bindusara’s only consort, nor in the usual order of things would the son that she was eventually to bear be considered the rightful heir to the throne.

Producing a son, in her case, seems to have required patience and guile. Because of her beauty, the concubines in Bindusara’s court prevented her from getting physically close to the emperor for they feared that if he made love to her he would no longer pay them any attention. She was, instead, taught by them to be an excellent barber. Little did they know that she, being determined to fulfil her ‘destiny’, would wield her razor in a way that would ensure she seduced her ruler-husband. Apparently, as she began to groom the king’s beard and hair, she did it with such skill that he began to relax completely and fall asleep. Since her grooming gave him so much pleasure, Bindusara decided to grant her a wish. It was then that she told him that she wanted him to pleasure her, make love to her. No ordinary man, Bindusara hesitated over her propositioning because of caste rules. He belonged to the Kshatriya (warrior) caste and he imagined that she, from the